

How to Structure Your Presentation and Best Deliver Your Argument(s)

Edited by Dr Niles Qi Li

For Theatre and Performance Studies and Film Studies

There are significant differences between a written paper, essay or report and a presentation. The introduction of an academic presentation should be considerably longer than that of a written text. Repetition is vital in a presentation. An audience needs to hear your core argument or ideas several times and in slightly different forms to understand it, whereas in a written text the reader can refer back if necessary. Informal rather than formal language should be used in an oral presentation.

Before you start preparing your contents, you should:

- Re-read our weekly lecture contents and find one interesting topic related to one or two theme(s) we examined on this course.
- Think of a 'catchy' title

Presenting your presentation:

When presenting your presentation you need to know your answers to the following questions:

- Is the purpose clearly stated: are you comparing (several films or theatrical plays), arguing, questioning...?
- Is the topic clearly stated: "In this presentation, I want to showcase the findings of recent research which shows that under certain conditions, xxxxxx"?
- Are your main arguments/ideas supported with evidence?
- Are all the materials relevant to the topic?
- Have you demonstrated your knowledge of the subject?
- Is the level of knowledge complexity suited to the audience?
- How do you reply to the research questions: long questions, 'mini papers' disguised as questions...?

If necessary, limit the scope of the presentation:

- "Although there are several theories (be specific), this talk will only focus on two ..."
- "focuses only on xxx as opposed to whose (which scholars') concepts or against whose argument ..."
- "Visual aesthetics, rather than spectatorship or narrative structure, will be considered ..."

Organise your presentation:

Most presentations are organised according to a predictable pattern. They have three main stages: introduction, body and conclusion (i.e. tell them what you are going to say; then say it; then tell them what you have said).

When a presentation does not have these clear sections, it can be very difficult for listeners to follow what is being said.

Format: better no more than 20 minutes. As our courses are engaging with visual aesthetics (TAP or Experimental Film), please make your PowerPoint visually striking. But the visuality of your PowerPoint should not undermine the credibility of your group research.

Introduction

This is the most crucial part of any presentation. You need to capture the audience's interest in your topic and establish rapport with them. Your introduction should let the audience know what they are going to hear in the presentation. They need to know what to expect in order to get interested and to be able to follow you. Giving them an outline of your presentation in your introduction enables them to do this.

You need to:

- capture the audience's attention with a question, quotation, anecdote, or interesting statistic, etc.
- tell them what your presentation will be about:
- main theme or main argument
- main points you will cover and the order in which you will cover them.

Body

The body of your presentation must be clearly organised with the main points highlighted. One effective technique is to number your ideas. Any idea which is new to your audience needs to be presented simply with supportive evidence or examples which will make it more easily understood. Each important idea should be presented several times in different ways within the body of your presentation. Your audience needs several opportunities to absorb the full meaning and the significance of the most important ideas. It is also important to state the links between your ideas clearly.

The body is where you develop your main ideas/argument, using supporting ideas/evidence. Use techniques that make it easy for the listener to follow your talk:

- number your ideas: "There are three main analytical dimensions..."
- arrange your ideas in logical order, such as chronological; cause and effect; problem-solution
- use transitional devices to help the audience follow the direction of your talk: "second...; another important point is...; on the other hand...; I would now like to move on and look at another aspect of the research..."
- support and clarify your ideas:

state the main argument by

- Providing support for your core/overall argument
- Explaining what films or theatrical performances you are examining to shore up your argument.
- Being specific with analytical terms, and explain why this sequence of the film or section of the play stays significant for your research project.
- Giving concise description, film stills (frame enlargement), and academic references (if time permits)
- Better using specific cases to support your argument, etc.
- Repeating important ideas using different words so the audience has several opportunities to absorb them
- Never making the information too dense or too loose.

Conclusion

The conclusion sums up main points. The conclusion should reinforce the central ideas of the presentation and signal a forceful ending. A weak, inconclusive, or apologetic closing detracts from a good presentation. You should show in your conclusion that you have covered all the points that you said you would in your introduction.

You should also show that you are confident, and that you have communicated effectively.

It is important to have a strong conclusion so the audience is left with a good impression.

- Summarise the main argument of your presentation.
- Don't introduce any new ideas.
- Work towards a strong ending – don't finish abruptly or say "That's all, thanks for listening". Perhaps leave the audience with something to think about.

Visual aids

A presentation can be enhanced by the effective use of overhead transparencies (slides), charts, pictures, posters, or PowerPoint presentations (with limited graphic/sound gimmicks). They provide variety and can help reinforce points made. However, you are still the main communicator of your message. Be familiar with your visual aids, refer to them specifically and only display them when you are referring to them, otherwise they will only be a distraction.

- Film stills or video clips, etc.: ensure that the size is appropriate for a large room. If necessary, back up with handouts.
- For video clips: ensure the segment shown is not too long in relation to the overall length of your presentation.
- Limit the amount of materials on each visual: your listeners should be able to read and understand a visual in five seconds or less.
- Do please show on your PowerPoint: your research topic, your research objects, the reasons why you want to examine them.
- Use film stills (adding explanation below the image) instead of words where possible. If you are examining a sequence, please pay attention to the order of the shots.